

Part of the Lingaraja temple complex in Bhubaneshwar.

One of the many puzzles of the Ashokan era is why that great emperor, having introduced a pan-Indian script, should have stuck with India’s remarkably crude system of punch-marked coinage when his Greek neighbours next door were producing high-quality coins bearing the ruler’s portrait and name on the obverse and images of their deities on the reverse. Such coins only began to appear in India in the first half of the second century CE during the rule of the Kushan king Kanishka, whose kingdom of Gandhara extended deep into Northern India and who came to be regarded by Chinese Buddhists as a second Ashoka even though his coinage shows him to have patronised a range of Vedic, Zoroastrian and Graeco-Bactrian deities besides Buddhism.